♠ ♥ ♦ ♣ All Fives ♣ ♦ ♥ ♠

A natural, disciplined bidding system built on common sense.

Philosophy

- **No crazy openings.** Bids mean what they look like.
- **Partner is reliable.** Trust his bids.
- **Use the opponents' information.**
- **Stay flexible.** This is an experimental system.
- **Most auctions are competitive.** Keep opening principles in mind.

Known Problems

- **1** - 3rd/4th seat 1NT is 15-17 HCP (not 12-14), because a weak NT blocks us without a chance at game. After a 3rd-seat suit opening, the NT rebid shows 12-14 balanced.
- **2** - The 4441 distribution. Every system struggles with this.
- **3** - 1♠ usually promises 5 spades, but with a strong 4333 hand it may show only 4 - which feels awkward.
- **4** - No agreed defense to opponents' 1NT opening yet. Currently we just pass. See hypothesis H-3 for a proposed structure.

The Central Idea

Every 1-level suit opening promises 5+ cards.

With extra strength (15-17 balanced), opener may hold only 4 cards and escapes to NT on the next bid, or makes a reverse (16+ HCP).

*So while the opening may show 4 cards, always think **5 by default**.*

Openings

1NT

1st/2nd seat: 12-14 HCP - shape 4333 / 4432 / 5332 (5332 includes a 5-card major).

3rd seat: 15-17 HCP - shape 4333 / 4432 / 5332.

Stronger range in 3rd seat. With a weak 12-14 hand we risk blocking ourselves from game when partner passed with 11.

Responses to 1NT

- **2♣** - Puppet Stayman - asks for a 5-card major
- **2♦** - Transfer to ♥
- **2♥** - Transfer to ♠
- **2♠** - Transfer to ♣
- **3♣** - Transfer to ♦

Puppet Stayman Continuations

After 2♣, opener replies:

- **2♦** - Denies 5-card major
- **2♥** - 5 hearts
- **2♠** - 5 spades

After 2♣ - 2♦ (denial), responder continues:

- **2♥** - 4 spades (not 4 hearts). Opener bids 2♠ with a fit, 2NT without.
- **2♠** - 4 hearts (not 4 spades). Opener bids 3♥ with a fit, 2NT without.
- **2NT** - No 4-card major, invitational
- **3NT** - No 4-card major, game values

*After the denial, responder's major bids are **transfer-like**: 2♥ shows spades, 2♠ shows hearts. This lets the strong hand (opener) become declarer.*

Opener completes transfers normally. With maximum (13-14) and 4-card support, opener may super-accept by jumping to 3 of the major (see H-4).

Escaping 1NTx - Helvic Wriggle

After 1NT - (X):

- **XX** - One-suited hand. Opener bids 2♣, responder passes or corrects.
- **2♣** - ♣ + ♦ (touching pairs)
- **2♦** - ♦ + ♥ (touching pairs)
- **2♥** - ♥ + ♠ (touching pairs)
- **Pass** - To play, or will bid later

After Pass - Pass - **XX** = SOS with non-touching pairs (♣+♥ or ♦+♠). Opener bids 2♣, responder passes or corrects.

- **Weak, shapely** - Wriggle (escape to a suit fit)
- **Weak, balanced** - Pass (hope for the best)
- **Strong (10+ HCP)** - Pass - penalty. Thank them for doubling.

If opponents doubled, they show 15+ HCP. If responder has 10+, our side has 22+ combined - the opponents made a mistake. Pass and collect the penalty.

1♣ / 1♦ / 1♥ / 1♠

1st/2nd seat: 12+ HCP, 5+ cards (4+ with extra strength and NT escape).

- With two 4-card suits, open the lower one first.

- With 15-17 balanced, open 4 cards and rebid NT.
- A 2NT rebid confirms 4 cards (not 5) in the opening suit.

3rd seat: 8+ HCP, 5+ cards (may be lighter than 1st/2nd seat). This is a passed-hand opening. Partner already passed, so there is no risk of missing game. The lighter range is tactical - competing for the partscore and directing the lead.

Continuations

Responder may raise with **3-card support** at the 2-level without fear - if opener had only 4, he simply rebids 2NT. Raises to 2NT and 3-level fits are **invitational**. Responder may raise with **3-card support** at the 2-level without fear - if opener had only 4, he simply rebids 2NT. Raises to 2NT and 3-level fits are **invitational**.

1-Minor Opening, 1-Major Response

Key rule: *After 1♣ or 1♦, a response of 1♥ or 1♠ promises* ***5 cards*** *if weak. With invitational+ strength, may show only 4 (with a plan to rebid NT or raise). Therefore,* ***opener may support with just 3 cards!***

1NT Response

6-9 HCP, no fit (at most 3 cards), no 5-card major, no game ambitions. We may miss a 4-4 fit, but if we are weak the opponents will bid. If not, everyone has misfit or balanced - NT is the right spot. See hypothesis H-2 for forcing 1NT as a future improvement.

Opener's rebids after 1♣ - 1♥

- **1♠** - 4+ spades, any strength (not a reverse - still at the 1-level)
- **1NT** - 15-17 HCP, balanced (confirms 4-card ♣ opening)
- **2♣** - 6+ clubs, or 5 with extra strength
- **2♦** - Reverse - 16+ HCP, 4+ ♦ (forcing)
- **2♥** - Simple raise - 3+ ♥ support, not a reverse
- **2♠** - Reverse - 16+ HCP, 4+ ♠ (forcing)
- **2NT** - 18-19 HCP, balanced (confirms 4-card ♣ opening)
- **3♣** - 6+ clubs, invitational

Quick Reference

- **1♣ - 1♦** - Natural, 4+ diamonds, waiting
- **1♣ - 1♥/♠** - 5+ if weak; 4+ if strong (invitational+)

2♣ - Semi-Strong (Benji)

Type 1 - Balanced

22-23 HCP: 2♣ - 2♦ - 2NT

Type 2 - Strong Major (Acol-style)

2♣ - 2♦ - 2♥/♠

- About 5 losers
- At least 5 cards in the suit (usually 6+)
- At least 3 top honours (A, K, Q)
- Partner needs roughly 2 fillers to make game

Type 3 - Reserved

Under investigation for strong two-suiters (18-21, 5-5+). See hypothesis H-6.

Responses to 2♣

- **2♦** - Waiting (0-7 HCP)
- **2♥** - Positive relay - balanced, no 5-card suit, 8+ HCP
- **2♠** - 5+ spades, 8+ HCP
- **2NT** - 5+ hearts, 8+ HCP
- **3♣ / 3♦** - 5+ clubs/diamonds, game-force, slam interest opposite 22-23

All non-2♦ responses are game-forcing (8+ HCP). This avoids the problem where after 2♣ - 2♦ - 2♥, responder cannot show a 5-card major.

2♦ - Strong Game-Force

Responder shows **controls** (Controls (Ace = 2, King = 1)):

- **2♥** - 0-1
- **2♠** - 2
- **2NT** - 3
- **3♣** - 4
- **3♦** - 5
- **3♥** - 6

Excellent for slam exploration. Opener immediately knows the combined control count and can place the contract or ask further.

2♥ / 2♠ - Weak Two

6-10 HCP, 6+ cards. Disciplined, especially when vulnerable.

Suit quality: At least 2 of the top 5 honours (A, K, Q, J, T).

- 6+ cards in the bid major
- 6-10 HCP (not less, not more)
- Decent suit quality - partner may raise pre-emptively or try for game
- Avoid opening a weak two with a void or a strong 4-card side suit

Ogust (2NT asks) - *Under investigation - see hypothesis H-1*

- **3♣** - Minimum (6-7 HCP), poor suit (0-1 top honours)

- **3♦** - Minimum (6-7 HCP), good suit (2+ top honours)
- **3♥** - Maximum (8-10 HCP), poor suit
- **3♠** - Maximum (8-10 HCP), good suit
- **3NT** - Solid suit (AKQxxx+) - to play

2NT - 20-21 HCP

Shape: 4333 / 4432 / 5332.

Responses to 2NT

- **3♣** - Puppet Stayman - asks for 5-card major
- **3♦** - Transfer to ♥
- **3♥** - Transfer to ♠
- **4NT** - Quantitative (inviting 6NT)

After 3♣, opener replies: 3♦ = denies 5-card major, then check for 4-card fits, 3♥ = 5 hearts, 3♠ = 5 spades.

Puppet Stayman fits better over 2NT than 1NT: the auction is already at the 3-level, so information leakage matters less, and finding the right major-suit game matters more.

3-level and Above

- **3♣ / 3♦ / 3♥ / 3♠** - Preemptive - Destructive block. Sound at unfavourable vulnerability., 7+ cards, ~5-10 HCP
- **3NT** - Gambling - AKQxxxx+ in a minor, no outside A or K
- **4♥ / 4♠** - To play - strong distributional hand or preemptive
- **4♣ / 4♦** - Strong preempt (8+ card minor, some values)
- **5♣ / 5♦** - Extreme preempt or to play

Competitive Bidding

Overcalls

- **Simple overcall** - 8-16 HCP, 5++ cards. Standard. A good suit is more important than HCP.
- **Jump overcall** - Weak - same as a weak two/three opening at the appropriate level - same as a weak two/three opening at the appropriate level.
- **Takeout double** - Support for all unbid suits, typically 12+ HCP or any 17+.

RAPTOR Convention

An overcall of **1NT** over opponent's suit opening shows:

- **4 cards in the unbid major**
- **5+ cards in a minor**
- **10-16 HCP**

We bid using the **minimax principle** (minimax - aiming to sign off, tolerate a suit). Comes up more frequently than a natural 1NT (15-17) overcall. The HCP range is 10-16 because lighter hands pass and stronger hands start with a takeout double.

After Opponent Opens 1♥ or 1♠

Shows: 4 in unbid major + 5+ in a minor.

- **Cue bid (opponent's suit)** - Asks for the major
- **2 of other minor** - To play
- **2 of unbid major** - Natural, 5+ cards, willing to play
- **2NT** - Invitational+, asks overcaller's shape

After Opponent Opens 1♣ or 1♦

Shows: 5+ in other minor + 4 in an unknown major.

- **2♣ (cheapest minor)** - Pass or correct to overcaller's minor
- **Cue bid (opponent's suit)** - Asks for the major
- **2♥ / 2♠** - Natural, 5+ cards
- **2NT** - Invitational+, asks overcaller's shape

Defense to Opponents' 1NT - *Under investigation - see hypothesis H-3*

Currently no agreed methods. currently pass.. Proposed structure:

- **X** - Penalty (15+ HCP)
- **2♣** - Both majors (5-4 either way, 10+ HCP)
- **2♦** - One major, 6+ cards (2NT asks which)
- **2♥** - Natural, good 6+ card suit
- **2♠** - Natural, good 6+ card suit
- **2NT** - Both minors (5-5+)

Defensive Carding

Use your head first, not partner's signals. In most situations, the bidding and dummy tell you everything. Signals are a last resort.

1. Attitude (Encourage / Discourage) (Encourage / Discourage)

- **Low card** - Encouraging - continue this suit
- **High card** - Discouraging - please switch

Exception: When partner leads the Ace, give count (even/odd) instead of attitude. If partner wants continuation from AK, he leads the King.

2. Count (Even / Odd) (Even / Odd)

- **High card** - Even number of cards
- **Low card** - Odd number of cards

Easy to remember: From a doubleton (even), play high.

3. Suit Preference on Discards (Italian Style) on Discards

- **Odd card (3, 5, 7, 9)** - Interest in the suit being discarded
- **Low even card (2, 4)** - Interest in the lower-ranking side suit
- **High even card (6, 8)** - Interest in the higher-ranking side suit

Signalling by Elimination

- **4 then 2** - Denies interest in the lower suit
- **9 then 3** - Denies interest in the discarded suit
- **8 then 6** - Denies interest in the higher suit

The higher the discard, the less reliable. The second discard confirms.

4. Opening Leads

Lead 3rd or 5th highest from length.

Vs suits: Prefer top-of-sequence leads. Avoid leading from unsupported honours into declarer's strength.

Vs NT: Lead your longest suit unless the bidding clearly shows opponents hold it.

From Length

- **K95** - 5 - 3rd highest
- **KQ752** - 2 - 5th highest

From Sequences

- **AKx(x)** - K (A asks for count)
- **KQx(x)** - K
- **QJx(x)** - Q
- **JTx(x)** - J
- **T9x(x)** - T
- **AKQx(x)** - A (then K - showing the sequence)

From Short Holdings

- **xx** - Higher card
- **xxx** - Middle, then high (MUD)
- **xxxx** - Highest safe, then low

Special rule: *If you hold the J, lead 4th highest. Example: from KJ732, lead the 3 (not the 2).*